Exegetical Fallacies

Second Edition

D. A. Carson

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W. Gordon Brown
In Memoriam

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about the interpretation of literary genres than I did. The little I added may be of use to some. And if this book ever goes to a third edition, perhaps that will be the time to add more to the fifth chapter.

Soli Deo gloria

D. A. Carson

Preface

a sounding board by which to give vent to personal prejudices. Doubtless I have in some measure failed, but readers who take too great offense in discovering just where I have damaged their preferred interpretations might profitably ask themselves to what extent their own prejudices have influenced their judgment.

My secretary Marty Irwin typed the manuscript under extremely short notice and considerable pressure; I am profoundly grateful for her efficiency and enthusiasm. Mark Reasoner gave valuable assistance with two of the indexes.

Soli Deo

Introduction

To focus on fallacies, exegetical or otherwise, sounds a bit like focusing on sin

Introduction

Introduction

to interpret the Scriptures; but it adds nothing to the knowledge

There is no sustained discussion in these pages of the Holy Spirit's role in our exegetical task. That subject is important and

(*eretō*) is no more intrinsically realistic than deriving the mean

LXX, "my precious life" (ψυχή μου) or "my whole soul"]; Ps. 25:16

such rendering of Romans as this: "I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the *dynamite* of God unto salvation for everyone who with a knowing tilt of the head, as if something profound or even esoteric has been uttered. This is not just the old root fallacy revisited. It is worse: it is an appeal to a kind of reverse etymology, the root fallacy compounded by anachronism. Did Paul think of dynamite when he penned this word? And in any case, even to mention dynamite as a kind of analogy is singularly inappropriate. Dynamite blows things up, tears things down, rips out rock, gouges holes, destroys things. The power of God concerning which Paul speaks he often identifies with the power that raised Jesus from the dead (e.g., Eph. 20); and as it operates in us, its goal is *(eis* salvation," Rom. 1:16, KJV), aiming for the wholeness and perfection implicit in the consummation of our salvation. Quite apart from the semantic anachronism, therefore, dynamite appears inadequate as a means of raising Jesus from the dead or as a means of conforming us to the likeness of Christ. Of course, what preachers are trying to do when they talk about dynamite is give some indication of the greatness of the power involved. Even so, Paul's measure is not dynamite, but the empty tomb. In exactly the same way, it is sheer semantic anachronism to note that in the text "God loves a cheerful giver" (2 Cor. 9:7) the Greek word behind "cheerful" *(hilaron)* and conclude that what God really loves is a hilarious giver. Perhaps we should play a laugh-track record while the offering plate is being circulated.

A third level of the same problem was painfully exemplified in three articles about blood in *Christianity Today*.[18] The authors did an admirable job of explaining the wonderful things science has discovered that blood can particular its cleansing role as it flushes out cellular impurities and transports nourishment to every part of the body. What a wonderful picture (we were told) of how the blood of Jesus Christ purifies us from every sin (1 John 1:7). In fact, it is nothing of the kind. Worse, it is irresponsibly mystical and theologically misleading. The

[18] Paul Brand and Philip Yancey, "Blood: The Miracle of Cleansing," *CT* 27/4 (Feb. 18, 1983): 12-15; "Blood: The Miracle of Life," (Mar. 4, 1983): 38-42; "Life in the Blood," *CT* 27/6 (Mar. 18, 1983): 18-21.

phrase the *blood of Jesus* refers to Jesus' violent, sacrificial death.[19] In general, the blessings that the Scriptures show to be accomplished or achieved by the blood of Jesus are equally said to be accomplished or achieved by the death of Jesus (e.g., justification, Rom. 3:21-26; 5:6-9; redemption, Rom. 3:24; Eph. 1:7; Rev. 5:9). If John tells us that the blood of thef t6753864 Tw1.219 Tc1.0

joined

male semen.[32] Understanding in this passage to mean "to beget" rather than "to give birth to," John 3:5 then reads, "Unless a man is begotten

ground in the Mandaean literature, the other in the
Both of these backgrounds are dubious even on the grounds of the dating of the sources; yet both scholars proceed to ascribe to the words of John's prologue the meanings of similar or identical words in fundamentally different corpora. Neither scholar exhibits much linguistic sensitivity to the need for contrastive paradigmatic equivalence or, more broadly, for equivalent contracts in the semantic fields of the texts being compared. I shall refer to these problems again (fallacy 16); suffice it to say here that Arthur Gibson, for instance, is rightly very harsh on
in this respect.[41]

7. Linkage of language and mentality

It was not long ago that this fallacy generated many books. If one mentions titles like *Hebrew Thought Compared with Greek*[42] in a room full of linguistically competent people, there will instantly be many pained expressions and groans. The heart of this fallacy is the assumption that any language so constrains the thinking processes of the people who use it that they are forced into certain patterns of thought and shielded from others. Language and mentality thus become confused. The *Theological Dictionary New Testament* was particularly guilty of this linkage; and it was to Barr's great credit that he exposed its bankruptcy, not only in his work on biblical but also in his narrower study comparing concepts of time in Hebrew and Greek thought.[44] This point has been made so often in recent

In J. T. Sanders's treatment of Philippians for instance, he establishes the stanza division to his own satisfaction, and then says, "The second line in either case then explicates what was said in the first line; this is done synonymously in the second stanza ('likeness' = 'fashion', 'of men' = 'like a man'). . . . 'Humbled himself is the to 'emptied
Gibson analyzes the problem.[55] Strictly speaking, "explicates" is incompatible with "synonymously" and perhaps with "equivalent"; for to the extent that two items are synonymous neither can explicate the other. The two items would have the same semantic value. Incidentally, although Gibson does not mention it, this is a major problem in most treatments of Hebrew poetry. Many scholars treat lexical units in Semitic poetry as synonymous, others as very rough "synonyms" that shed light on each other, and some confuse the two. It is arguable that the habits of Hebrew poets are diverse enough to admit both strict synonymy and explication in most poems, but not at the same time in the same pair of items![56] Also, the parallels Sanders draws are not exactly synonymous. Even "of a man" "are semantically asymmetrical regarding 'of and 'like' and *quantificationally distinct in men/man;* so it is, at the most, only at some levels that the equated components share semantic levels, with differences at others, while Sanders distinguishes neither group."[57] Third, the equations Sanders advances could in theory be reconstructed as hyponymic relations (i.e., the pairs of items do not have the same semantic values: they do not mean exactly the same things, but they have the same referents [they make reference to the same realities, even though their meaning is different]).[58] Unfortunately, Sanders does not see his equations that way.

54. J. T. Sanders, *The New Testament Christological Hymns* (Cambridge: University Press, 1971), 10.

55. Gibson, *Biblical Semantic Logic,*

56. The standard Old Testament introductions treat these matters in a cursory but recent journal literature boasts many fresh studies on parallelism in Hebrew poetry.

57. Gibson, *Biblical Semantic Logic,* 45.

58. Following Gibson's lead, the label *hyponymic* in this context springs from John Lyons, *Introduction to Theoretical Linguistics* (Cambridge: University Press, 1968), especially 453-60. For extended discussion of problems of synonymy, see Ullmann, *Semantics,* 141-55.

FIGURE 1

		Entries			
		man	**woman**	**boy**	**girl**
C	**human**	+	+	+	+
g	**adult**	+	+	-	-
		+	-	+	-

The point of this rather painful exercise is not to denigrate the work of a biblical scholar, since one could argue, for instance, that Sanders does not mean to take "synonymously" in the same rigorous way that modern linguists demand. He might be a "layman" as far as linguistic theory is concerned, and therefore permitted to use terms like "synonyms" in a nontechnical way. But that is just the problem, for the theological agenda is illegitimately controlling the equations, flattening semantic distinctions, violating levels of meaning by squashing them into one equation, with the result that the text cannot speak with all its force, with its full semantic power. The fallacy is the unwarranted belief that "synonyms" are identical in more ways than the evidence allows.

To present the second problem, I must say a little about ponential analysis. This kind of study attempts to isolate the components of meaning (i.e., the semantic components) of (usually) words. Figure 1 provides a frequently repeated example. The chart is self-explanatory. But notice that the semantic components (human, adult, male) do not exhaust the possible constituentsle 0.709 Tc(Figur) Tj0 Tc(e) Tj2.1922 0 Tc(d).106 Tw 0

case of many words, the list of semantic "components" becomes very long and cumbersome indeed. Moreover, there is no agreed procedure for analyzing terms componentially, and therefore different scholars sometimes achieve quite different
which is not very reassuring. But even where two analyses of a term agree, they do not usually claim to list all of the elements that go into the meaning of the term under scrutiny, since componential analysis normally provides only the elements of referential meaning.

Perhaps it will now be a little clearer why synonyms are so difficult to handle. In one sense, of course, two terms are virtually never strictly synonymous if by "synonymous" we are saying that *wherever they are used* the two terms mean exactly the same thing denotatively and connotatively, in their semantic components and in the cognitive information they convey and in the emotional freight they carry, to all people who speak the language. But a pair of words can be strictly synonymous in certain contexts; each case must be decided on its own merits. To illustrate with another commonly used diagram, figure 2, the terms A and B may be strictly synonymous in a particular context where they enjoy semantic overlap (i.e., overlapping meanings, indicated by the shaded area). For strict synonymy, of course, the semantic overlap must include not only referential meaning, but also all the aspects that go into meaning; for otherwise the terms A and B are "synonymous" at some levels and not at others.

FIGURE 2

We are now equipped to resume our discussion of
and *(phileo),* introduced in the discussion about the root fallacy. There we saw that *(agapao)* does not always refer to a "good" love or a sacrificial love or a divine love, and certainly there is nothing in the root to convey such a meaning. But the question arises whether the well-known exchange between Jesus and Peter reported in John using the two different verbs, is intended to convey a distinction in meaning, or to provide an example of semantic overlap, of synonymy. The pattern is shown in figure 3.

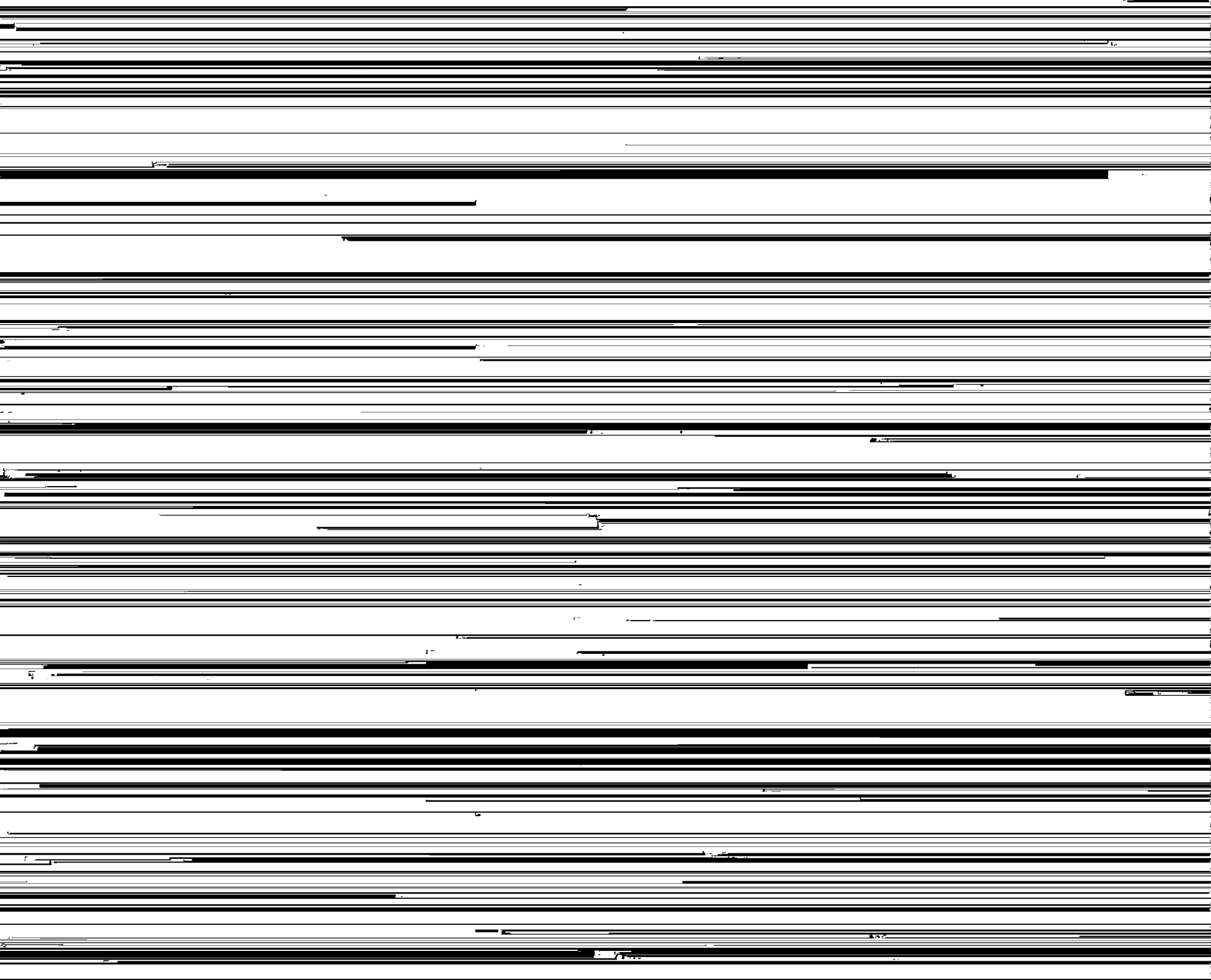
FIGURE 3

Jesus' question Peter's response

For various reasons, I doubt very much that there is an intended distinction. If I were setting out to prove the point, I would have to discuss the significance of "the third time," exegete the passage in some detail, review the evidence that John regularly introduces expressions that are either precisely synonymous or roughly so,[60] and so forth. But most of those who
that there is a distinction to be made in John's use of the two verbs do so on one of two grounds. First, they argue that translators of the Septuagint and New Testament writers have *(agapao,* to love) and *(agape,* love) with special meaning to provide an adequate expression by which to talk about the love of God; and only this accounts for the word's rapid rise to prominence in our literature. But this argument has been overturned by the diachronic study of Robert who presents convincing evidence that *(aga-*

60. Refer to Leon Morris, *Studies in the Fourth Gospel* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1969), 293-319.
The less sophisticated, of9 527.0400.032 Twiil Tc(0j0 Tc(57.3252(s0 Tc(





The aorist tense

More than two decades ago, Frank Stagg wrote an article about "The Abused Aorist."[3] The problem as he saw it was that competent scholars were deducing from the presence of an aorist verb that the action in question was "once for all" or "completed." The problem arises in part because the aorist is often described as the punctiliar tense. Careful grammarians, of course, operating within the traditional categories, understood and explained that this does not mean the aorist could

Stagg has not been the only one to warn against the abuse of the aorist;[4] yet one still finds not only preachers but also competent scholars making the mistake of resting too much weight on it. For instance, in the excellent commentary on the Epistle to the Hebrews by Philip Edgcumbe Hughes, we are told, regarding the opening verses, "The aorist tense, used both of God's speaking by the prophets and also of his speaking by Christ *[elalesen])*, indicates that God has finished speaking in both cases."[5] The conclusion, arguably, is theologically correct; but it is not proved by this argument. Commenting on with respect to the Son's "becoming" superior to the angels, Hughes writes, "The aorist participle *[genomenos]*, 'having refers, as Spicq points out, to 'a dated event of A final example comes from a recent article in which Heikki Raisanen, commenting on Romans 3:27 ("Where, then, is boasting? It is *excluded";* NIV, italics added), writes, "In any case, the aorist *[exekleisthe])* certainly means that the exclusion was a once-for-all act."[7]

Nevertheless, it is possible to go too far with this sort of criticism—a point well illustrated in a recent article by Charles R. Smith.[8] Smith draws attention to Stagg's work; and then not only does he argue that Stagg has been ignored, but also he seeks to go beyond Stagg by insisting that the evidences

2. Interpretations that ignore the Bible's story-line

Precisely because so many interpreters do not hold that there is an omniscient God who actually stands behind all of the Bible, they feel free to read parts of it in ways that are deliberately set over against other parts of the Bible. Postmodern biases have accentuated this trend. Thus it has been argued that Song of Solomon is an instance of pornographic literature;[7] that James and Paul are utterly irreconcilable; that the Gospels reflect not only different communities but irreconcilable differences among those communities; and much more of the same. Many recent books have as their primary aim the articulation of as many mutually competing interpretations as possible.[8] The only incorrect view is the view that any view should be labeled incorrect; the only heresy is the view that there is such a thing as heresy.

Christians who have a high view of Scripture, a commitment to truth because they serve a God who knows all truth perfectly, and who recognize that although in our finiteness and sinfulness we may not know truth absolutely or perfectly but nevertheless truly, will not want to go down such paths. They will be interested in discovering how the Bible fits together. For fit together it does, tracing its way along a story-line from the creation and fall, through great redemptive-historical appointments to the consummation in a new heaven and a new earth.

3. Fallacies that arise from a bleak insistence on working outside the Bible's "givens"

This is painfully common today. The current social agenda is taken as the assumed "given" and the text is made to conform to it. Postmoderns see nothing wrong with this procedure; indeed, they are inclined to think it is inevitable. But the result is often fantastic.

7. David J. A. Clines, "Why Is There a Song of Songs and What Does It Do to You When You Read It?" *Jian Dao* 1 (1994): 3–27.

8. E.g., J. Cheryl Exum and David J. A. Clines, *The New Literary Criticism and the Hebrew Bible* (Valley Forge: Trinity Press International, 1993); David Seeley, *Deconstructing the New Testament* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1994); Stephen D. Moore, *Mark and Luke in Poststructuralist Perspectives: Jesus Begins to Write* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1992); Francis Watson, ed., *The Open Text: New Directions for Biblical Studies?* (London: SCM Press, 1993).

For example, Castelli argues that when a powerful figure such as Paul urges that others imitate him (1 Cor. 11:1), this is always a power move that splits people into insiders and outsiders, conformists and nonconformists. Such urging is inherently a political move that privileges a certain view of reality and marginalizes others who disagree. The appeal for unity becomes a pretext to justify hegemony. What we should be doing, rather, is reinstating the value of difference.[9]

All of this presupposes that the God of the Bible does not exist, or that if he exists he has no inclination to demand that his image-bearers live in a certain way, and not in other ways. The self-confidence with which the value of unqualified "difference" is put forth is staggering, and staggeringly naive. But this sort of interpretation is no longer uncommon.

Historical Fallacies

1. Uncontrolled historical reconstruction

The fallacy is in thinking that speculative reconstruction of first-century Jewish and Christian history should be given much weight in the exegesis of the New Testament documents. A substantial block of New Testament scholars have traced a network of theological trajectories to explain how the church changed its thinking from decade to decade and from place to place. The church was once "enthusiastic" and charismatic, then settled into "early catholicism" with its structures, hierarchies, formulas, and creeds. It looked forward at one time to the impending return of Christ, only to be forced by his continued absence to construct a theory of a delayed parousia and settle down for the long haul. It began in a Jewish context by calling Jesus the Messiah and ended in a Gentile context by calling him Lord and ascribing deity to him.

Now there is just enough truth in this reconstruction that it cannot simply be written off. The Book of Acts itself demonstrates how the church came to wrestle with the place of Gentiles in the fledgling messianic community, faced the problem of the relation between the Mosaic covenant of law and the gos-

9. Elizabeth A. Castelli, *Imitating Paul: A Discourse of Power* (Louisville: Westminster/John Knox Press, 1991).

pel of grace in Christ Jesus, and learned to adapt its presentation of the good news to new contexts. Nevertheless the reconstruction of church history that is held by many biblical scholars goes much further, and concludes, for instance, that the references to elders in Acts and the Pastorals prove those documents are late, because elders belong to the "early catholic" period of the church. Again and again the New Testament documents are squeezed into this reconstructed history and assessed accordingly.

The problem is that we have almost no access to the history of the early church during its first five or six decades *apart* from the New Testament documents. A little speculative reconstruction of the flow of history is surely allowable if we are attempting to fill in some of the lacunae left by insufficient evidence; but it is methodologically indefensible to use those speculations to undermine large parts of the only evidence we have. If a scholar feels that some of that evidence is unreliable or misleading, then the canons of scholarship afford him or her every opportunity to make a case for disregarding that evidence; but it is a fallacy to think that speculative reconstructions have any force in overturning the evidence. It is far wiser for a scholar who discounts some piece of evidence to make the best possible case for that judgment and then admit he does not know what really did happen historically, or even venture some cautious speculation about what happened, than to try to use the speculation itself as a telling point to throw out the evidence.

This problem is so endemic to New Testament scholarship that many of the divisions between conservative and liberal scholars can be traced to this methodological fallacy. I see no possibility of substantial movement unless this problem is directly addressed.

Worse yet, this uncontrolled historical reconstruction is often linked with the more extravagant approaches to form criticism to produce double uncontrolled work.[10] To cite but one example, in his treatment of the parable of the ten virgins (Matt.

10. I have outlined some of the inherent weakness of form and redaction criticism as commonly practiced in contemporary New Testament studies in "Redaction Criticism: On the Use and Abuse of a Literary Tool," in *Scripture and Truth*, ed. D. A. Carson and John D. Woodbridge (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1983), 119–42, 376–81.

25:1–13) Rudolf Bultmann makes a number of preliminary observations and then comments, "It is no longer possible to decide whether an original Similitude underlies it. Its content—the delay of the Parousia—also reveals that it is a secondary formulation."[11] Thus, the least defensible elements of form criticism combine with the most speculative historical reconstruction to form critical judgments absolutely devoid of substantive evidence.

2. *Fallacies of causation*

Fallacies of causation are faulty explanations of the causes of events. Fischer lists quite a few,[12] including *post hoc, propter hoc*, "the mistaken idea that if event B happened after event A, it happened because of event A";[13] *cum hoc, propter hoc*, which "mistakes correlation for cause";[14] *pro hoc, propter hoc*, "putting the effect before the cause";[15] the reductive fallacy, which "reduces complexity to simplicity, or diversity to uniformity, in causal explanations";[16] the fallacy of reason as cause, which "mistakes a causal for a logical order, or vice versa";[17] and the fallacy of responsibility as cause, which "confuses a problem of ethics with a problem of agency in a way which falsifies both."[18]

It is not difficult to find examples of these and other fallacies in the writings of New Testament scholars. Granted that Edwin M. Yamauchi and others are right in arguing that there is no good evidence of full-blown Gnosticism in the pre-Christian period,[19] it is difficult to resist the conclusion that a great many

11. Rudolf Bultmann, *History of the Synoptic Tradition* (New York: Harper and Row, 1963), 176. This book boasts combinations like this on almost every page.

12. Fischer, *Historians' Fallacies*, 164–82.

13. Ibid., 166.

14. Ibid., 167.

15. Ibid., 169.

16. Ibid., 172.

17. Ibid., 180.

18. Ibid., 182.

19. See especially Edwin M. Yamauchi, *Pre-Christian Gnosticism: A Survey of the Proposed Evidences*, 2d ed. (Grand Rapids: Baker, 1983), and his excellent review of James M. Robinson, ed., *The Nag Hammadi Library* (San Francisco: Harper and Row, 1978) in "Pre-Christian Gnosticism in the Nag Hammadi Texts?" *Church History* 48 (1979): 129–41.

of the connections drawn by scholars (especially those of the "history of religions school") who believe Christianity is an offshoot of Gnosticism are nothing more than examples of *pro hoc, propter hoc*, the worst kind of causal fallacy. Of course, a more charitable interpretation of their opinions would point out that those who hold them believe Gnosticism is in fact pre-Christian, and therefore their connections are not examples of the *pro hoc, propter hoc* fallacy. Even so, many such connections then fall afoul of the *post hoc, propter hoc* fallacy until the connection has been rigorously established.

An example of *cum hoc, propter hoc* that occurs frequently in evangelical preaching runs as follows: Paul in his Athenian address (Acts 17:22–31) erred in trying to approach his hearers philosophically rather than biblically, and his own acknowledgment of his error turned up in 1 Corinthians, where he pointed out that at Corinth, the next stop after Athens, he resolved to know nothing while he was with them except Jesus Christ and him crucified (1 Cor. 2:2). This exegesis seriously misunderstands the address at the Areopagus and Luke's purpose in telling it; but it also connects pieces of information from two separate documents and without evidence affirms a causal connection: because Paul allegedly failed miserably in Athens, therefore he resolved to return to his earlier practice. In fact, there is a geographical and temporal correlation (Paul did travel to Corinth from Athens), but not a shred of evidence for causation.

3. *Fallacies of motivation*

Again, it is Fischer who most ably lays these out.[20] Motivational fallacies might be considered a subset of causal fallacies: "Motivational explanation might be understood as a special kind of causal explanation in which the effect is an intelligent act and the cause is the thought behind it. Or it might be conceived in noncausal terms, as a paradigm of patterned behavior."[21]

I shall not list an array of such fallacies. All of them have to do with explaining a certain historical development on the basis of specific choices and preferences. In the worst cases, it is an

20. Fischer, *Historians' Fallacies*, 187–215.
21. Ibid., 187.

attempt to psychoanalyze one or more of the participants in a past event, without having access to the patient—indeed, without having access to anything more than fragmentary records of the event.

The highest proportion of motivational fallacies crops up today in some radical redaction critical study of the New Testament. Every redactional change must have a *reason* behind it; so enormous creative energy is spent providing such reasons. They are most difficult to disprove; but apart from those cases where the text itself provides rich and unambiguous evidence, they are rarely more than raw speculation. For instance, because Robert H. Gundry holds that Matthew's birth narratives are dependent on Luke, he feels he must explain every change. The Magi meet Jesus in a house (2:11–12), not a stable, because a stable is "hardly a fit place for distinguished Magi [whom Gundry does not think are historical anyway] to offer expensive gifts to a king."[22] In other words, Gundry simply asserts that the reason Matthew changed "stable" to "house" is to accommodate a theological motif. Gundry, of course, has no independent access to Matthew's mind: he only has the text of this Gospel. Yet he is prepared to elucidate Matthew's reason, his motives, for this putative change, and for literally thousands more cases solely on the basis of a certain redaction critical theory. I am not very sanguine about the results.[23]

4. *Conceptual parallelomania*

This is a conceptual counterpart to the verbal parallelomania I treated in chapter 1. Moisés Silva lists some examples from Edith Hamilton's book about Greek culture.[24] She describes Sophoclean tragedy in the words "Lo, I come . . . to do thy will" (Heb. 10:7, KJV, citing Ps. 40:6–8, LXX); and Ephesians 6:12 ("For our struggle is not against flesh and blood," NIV) becomes in her hands an illustration of the fact that the most divisive

22. Robert H. Gundry, *Matthew: A Commentary on His Literary and Theological Art* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1982), 31.
23. See the review of Gundry's commentary in *Trinity Journal* 3 (1982): 71–91.
24. Moisés Silva, "The New Testament Use of the Old Testament: Text Form and Authority," in *Scripture and Truth*, ed. D. A. Carson and John D. Woodbridge (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1983), 157.

human conflicts are those waged "for one side of the truth to the suppression of the other side."[25]

Conceptual parallelomania is particularly inviting to those who have taken advanced training in a specialized field (psychology, sociology, some area of history, philosophy, education) but who have no more than a serious Sunday-school knowledge of the Scriptures. Many of the specialists who fall into these fallacies are devout believers who want to relate the Bible to their discipline. They think they have a much firmer grasp of Scripture than they do; and the result is frequently appalling nonsense.

25. Edith Hamilton, *The Greek Way* (1930; New York: Avon, 1973), 187, 247.

5

Concluding Reflections

At this stage I do not propose to start listing more fallacies, but to prime the pump of future discussion by briefly listing some areas where more opportunities for fallacies lurk in the darkness to catch the unwary. This list is not comprehensive, merely suggestive.

Opportunities for Even More Fallacies

1. Problems related to literary genre

There are many. Our modern definitions of "parable" or "allegory" may not be quite what ancient writers meant by these terms. The new hermeneutic has established much of its theory by studying parables, which in Jesus' hands were often meant to shock and "interpret" the hearer to himself, as much as to be interpreted by the hearer; but the theories work less well in a tractate letter or a discourse. How may we shape our questions about genre by the genre being studied? Again, many studies in this area fall afoul of the need for evenhanded balancing of continuities *and discontinuities* when two pieces of literature are being compared.

One of the most common errors preachers make in the area of literary genre occurs in their handling of Proverbs. A proverb is neither a promise nor case law. If it is treated that way, it may prove immensely discouraging to some believers when things do not seem to work out as the "promise" seeks to suggest.

Perhaps the easiest way of making the point is by comparing two proverbs that are located side by side. "Do not answer a fool according to his folly," Proverbs 26:4 pronounces. The next

verse adds, "Answer a fool according to his folly." The second part of each verse helps us sort out this strange conjunction:

> Do not answer a fool according to his folly,
> or you will be like him yourself (26:4).
>
> Answer a fool according to his folly,
> or he will be wise in his own eyes (26:5).

A thoughtful reader will have to ask when it is best to follow one verse or the other. That question will prompt reflection on the second line of each verse: Will my "foolish" response be bringing me down to the other's level (26:4), or will it be pricking the other's pretensions and warning him of his course (26:5)? How can I tell?

In other words, proverbs often demand meditation, subtle reflection on the circumstances under which the proverb applies, recognition that the proverb provides us with God-given wisdom on how to live under the fear of God, rather than simplistic univocal promises or the like.

Similarly, the careful interpreter will work through the way Hebrew poetry, apocalyptic, historical passages, gospels, laments, and many other forms, actually work—how they convey meaning and truth, how they bring encouragement or instruction or warning, and so forth.

2. Problems related to the New Testament use of the Old

These include the nature of the Old Testament's authority when the connection is typological, the danger of a purely fideistic appeal in the difficult passages, the question of whether (and when) the quotation is meant to bring the Old Testament context with it, and much more. These problems all invite fallacies of various kinds.

3. Arguments from silence

One reviewer of James B. Hurley's book on the roles of men and women criticized it rather severely for not adequately considering the silences of Jesus regarding limitations on women.[1]

1. Linda Merandante, writing about James B. Hurley, *Man and Woman in Biblical Perspective* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1981), in *TSF Bull* 6 (Jan.–Feb. 1983): 21–22.

Scholars usually recognize that arguments from silence are weak; but they are stronger if a case can be made that in any particular context we might have expected further comment from the speaker or narrator. My purpose is not to arbitrate this particular dispute, but to point out that various fallacies can attach themselves either to arguments from silence or to the construction of contexts used to give arguments from silence some force.

4. Problems relating to juxtapositions of texts

Some of these are forced to the surface when we consider the Arian efforts to link John 10:30 ("I and the Father are one," NIV) and John 17:20–23 ("I pray . . . that all of them may be one, Father, just as you are in me and I am in you," NIV). What gives interpreters the right to link certain verses together, and not others? The point is that all such linking eventually produces a grid that affects the interpretation of other texts. There may be fallacies connected not only with the way individual verses are interpreted, but also with the way several passages are linked—and then also with the way such a link affects the interpretation of the next verse that is studied!

For instance, it is difficult to resist the conclusion that George W. Knight's treatment of 1 Corinthians 14:33b–38, regarding the silence of women in the churches, requires that the Corinthian readers had already read 1 Timothy 2:11–15, which on any chronology was not yet written; for Knight himself, recognizing that in the light of 1 Corinthians 11:5 the silence referred to in 1 Corinthians 14:34 cannot be absolute, appeals to 1 Timothy 2:11–15 to find appropriate limitations to the prohibition.[2] Other approaches are possible; but in any case a rationale is needed for this particular (or any other) juxtaposition of texts on which so much is made to depend.

I do not propose to offer tentative methodological solutions to such problems; but it is quite clear that many of the disputes in Christianity—whether long-standing debates over the relation between God's sovereignty and man's responsibility, or more recent foci of interest such as the relationships between

2. George W. Knight III, *The New Testament Teaching on the Role Relationship of Men and Women* (Grand Rapids: Baker, 1977), 36–40.

men and women in the Christian church—revolve around inconsistencies, errors, and fallacies in this area. The kinds of fallacies involved are very often of the sort that have already been treated in this book; the application of what we have learned to problems of constructing a consistent biblical theology would take us into new twists and turns of thought that stand beyond the reach of this book. Certainly a great deal more work needs to be done in this area.

5. Problems relating to statistical arguments

Many exegetical judgments are shaped in part by redaction critical decisions that depend on numbers—the frequency with which a certain word or phrase occurs in a specified corpus, whether it occurs in unambiguously redactional material or elsewhere, and so forth.

But there are many methodological fallacies connected with statistical arguments, fallacies of which most New Testament scholars are only vaguely aware. For instance, many redactional decisions are based on counts of words that occur only four or five times. Statistically it can be shown that the possibility of error in such judgment calls is 50 percent, 70 percent, 80 percent, or even higher. Moreover, word frequency statistics are normally calculated on the basis of the null hypothesis. This statistical model figures out how likely various occurrences would be in comparison with a random drawing of words out of a barrel. But writers do not choose words that way. There may be convincing contextual or topical reasons why some words are chosen in one context and not in another.

More serious yet, too few studies have been done in comparative literature to know if there are standard patterns of variability within the writings of one author. If enough of such studies were done (and ideally it would take thousands), we could eliminate our reliance on the null hypothesis.

Again, most redaction critical judgments treat "redactional" words and phrases, and sometimes the passages in which they are embedded, as late additions or as references to nonhistorical material. But statistical tests have never been done to determine how often other writers (e.g., Josephus) use their own words and combine them with sources at their disposal to relate matters that are historical. Such comparative studies are sadly lacking.

6. The rise of structuralism[3]

A new generation of fallacies is in the process of being created as this relatively young discipline is applied to biblical studies.

7. Problems in distinguishing the figurative and the literal

It is quite common to find interpretations that mistake the literal for the figurative, or vice versa. The theology of some cults *depends* on such misreadings. James W. Sire points out that Christian Science offers figurative interpretations of scores of biblical words, without offering exegetical justification (e.g., "dove" is a symbol for divine Science, purity, and peace; "evening" symbolizes "instances of mortal thought; weariness of mortal mind; obscured view; peace and rest"), and Mormonism offers a literal interpretation of many apparently figurative uses of words (e.g., God must have a body because the text speaks of God's strong right arm).[4] But what are the controlling principles for determining figurative/literal distinctions? A good place to begin such study is G. B. Caird's book;[5] but in any case the problem offers another fertile field for fallacies of exegesis.

Bringing the Pieces Together

This discussion has necessarily treated fallacies piecemeal; but in the actual work of exegesis, some passages by their sheer complexity stir up a multiplicity of fallacies at the same time—in the same way that the law stirs up sin. I think of passages such as Psalm 110; Isaiah 52:13–53:12; Matthew 16:13–23; Ephesians 5:21–30; and Revelation 20:1–6.

Then on top of the strictly exegetical fallacies, we face new dangers when we seek to apply to our lives the meaning of the text we have discovered—that is, when we ask how the Bible is

3. For an easy introduction to what "structuralism" means, refer to J. P. Louw, *Semantics of New Testament Greek* (Philadelphia: Fortress; Chico, Calif.: Scholars Press, 1982), 91–158. For more detailed bibliography of the standard discussions, see D. A. Carson, "Hermeneutics," *Themelios 5/2* (Jan. 1980): 12–20.

4. James W. Sire, *Scripture Twisting: Twenty Ways the Cults Misread the Bible* (Downers Grove, Ill.: Inter-Varsity, 1980), 66–70.

5. G. B. Caird, *The Language and Imagery of the Bible* (London: Duckworth, 1980).

to be used.[6] May we take any narrative paradigmatically? Must interpretations of discrete passages be related to salvation-historical wholeness? More practically, is footwashing an institution for the church to observe? Identifying and avoiding fallacies related to such questions would require quite a different book.

But I do not want to end on so negative a note. There is a danger that readers will conclude their perusal of this little book enslaved to deep fears about their own inadequacies for the task of exegesis. A little self-doubt will do no harm and may do a great deal of good: we will be more open to learn and correct our mistakes. But too much will shackle and stifle us with deep insecurities and make us so much aware of methods that we may overlook truth itself.

I have no easy answer to this dilemma. But we will not go far astray if we approach the Bible with a humble mind and then resolve to focus on central truths. Gradually we will build up our exegetical skills by evenhanded study and a reverent, prayerful determination to become like the workman "who correctly handles the word of truth" (2 Tim. 2:15, NIV).

6. See David H. Kelsey, *The Uses of Scripture in Recent Theology* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1975).

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